Students Studying in Canada

HEALTH INSURANCE

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HEALTH INSURANCE IN CANADA

Comprehensive health insurance is mandatory for all international students studying in Canada. Travel insurance is not comprehensive, as it often only covers accidents. **Health insurance is not included in your fees and you need to purchase it separately.**

GuardMe Health Insurance is the only health insurance we accept, it is **mandatory** to purchase GuardMe Insurance as an international student attending a Northeastern University Canadian campus. The only exceptions for GuardMe are the provincial health plans such as MSP (Vancouver) and OHIP (Ontario).

You may be asked for proof of your health insurance on arriving to Canada by the Border Agents. Students are also required to submit a copy of their GuardMe insurance plan in their myOGS account once they arrive in Canada.

Insurance options in Canada varies across provinces.

NEW INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS AT NORTHEASTERN TORONTO

The Ontario Health Insurance Plan (OHIP) is not available (http://www.health.gov.on.ca/en/public/programs/ohip/ohipfaq_mn.aspx) for most international students studying in the province.

Students are therefore **required to purchase the GuardMe health insurance plan** that is comprehensive and provides for the cost of health services, medical treatments, doctor's visits, and prescriptions. Northeastern University has partnered with GuardMe insurance to provide students with comprehensive, affordable health insurance. Health insurance fees are not included in your tuition.

All international students studying at Northeastern Toronto are expected to have continuous (no gaps) health insurance coverage with GuardMe throughout their entire study, including during co-op terms.

The NU GuardMe insurance policy provides students with 24-hours a day, seven days per week support and a wide range of benefits for emergencies, new and emergent conditions, and medically necessary treatments. Your policy has also been designed to cover prescription medication for new and emergent conditions. You can also purchase insurance for your accompanying family members, as they will need to have insurance also.

New Students – Instructions for Purchasing Health Insurance

The health insurance purchase is a two (2) step process.

Step One (1)

Early Arrival Insurance: If you are arriving in Canada **prior to September 1st (Fall students) or January 1st (Winter/Spring students)**, please purchase the **Early Arrival** insurance (https://www.guard.me/neutoronto/department/early-arrivals). Please proceed to Step Two (2).

If you are not arriving in Canada before September 1st or January 1st, then please go straight to Step Two (2).

- This link remains open year-round for early arrivals. If you have booked your flight to Canada, please feel free to purchase the Early Arrival insurance. You should ensure that the insurance start date is the day of your arrival into Canada, and the end date will automatically be August 31st or December 31st.

- Remember that if you are arriving in Canada prior to September 1st or January 1st, this is just Step One (1). You have to make a second mandatory purchase – see below.

Step Two (2)

New Students Insurance: All new international students need to purchase the **New Students** health insurance (https://www.guard.me/neutoronto/department/new-students).

- Please note that it is **mandatory** to purchase the New Students insurance for the default dates when applying. There are no exceptions.
- If you are a **Fall** student the link will open on **July 1st** for purchasing.

What is the approximate cost of GuardMe?

- The cost of GuardMe varies by time and by how many people are included in your policy.
- GuardMe is charged at $1.93 per day for one person under one policy.
    - For Fall (September) students you can expect an upfront cost of $700-$750 CAD for the primary policy holder.
    - For Winter/Spring (January) students you can expect an upfront cost of $450-$500 CAD for the primary policy holder.

You will be required to show proof of insurance to attend the Toronto Campus as an international student. Holds will be placed on student accounts for those missing health insurance and you will not be allowed to continue your studies until you submit your health insurance. You will need to extend your policy (https://www.guard.me/neutoronto/department/extension-students) before it expires as you are required to have coverage for the entire duration of your studies.

NEW INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS AT NORTHEASTERN VANCOUVER

International students in BC are in most cases eligible for the provincial health coverage – Medical Services Plan (MSP). However, since the wait period to receive your MSP card after applying is around 90 days, you will need to apply for GuardMe Health Insurance for your first 90 days in Canada, starting from the day you arrive – **this is mandatory**.

To purchase **GuardMe** prior to your arrival, please see the options below:

- If you are a **New Student**, please purchase the New Student's insurance plan here (https://www.guard.me/neuvancouver/department/apply-for-insurance/new-students) for your first 90 days in BC.
- If you are looking to **extend** your current GuardMe health plan, please see here (https://www.guard.me/neuvancouver/department/apply-for-insurance/afi-extensions).
- When you get MSP, we would also advise you to take a look at the top-up plans from GuardMe. The **GuardMe Plus** top-up plan that NU has selected for its students provides benefits that have been designed with the unique needs of international students in mind. You can purchase a a plan here (https://www.guard.me/neuvancouver/department/apply-for-insurance/afi-extensions-with-msp).

You may be required to show continuous proof of insurance to attend the Vancouver Campus as an international student.

What is the approximate cost of GuardMe?

- GuardMe is charged at $1.93 per day for one person under one policy.
- For New Students on the Vancouver campus purchasing insurance, you should plan for a cost of about $170 – $190 for 90 days. This does not include dependents. Adding dependents will change the cost.

After Your Arrival to British Columbia (BC)

You should apply for MSP (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents/eligibility-and-enrolment/how-to-enrol) as soon as you arrive in BC.
You may also apply for MSP for your dependents (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents/eligibility-and-enrolment/are-you-eligible#dependents:~:text=a%20calendar%20year-,Dependents,-Dependents%20of%20MSP).

Please note: There is a three-month wait period for this plan, and during this period students need to enrol for GuardMe. Some students may choose to continue with GuardMe even after the MSP plan starts, to provide additional coverage.

Wait Period Coverage

Students are required to purchase GuardMe as it is comprehensive and provides for the cost of health services, medical treatments, doctor's visits, and prescriptions for 90 days while waiting for your MSP Card. Northeastern University has partnered with GuardMe insurance to provide students with comprehensive, affordable health insurance.

The NU GuardMe insurance policy provides students with 24-hours a day, seven days per week support and a wide range of benefits for emergencies, new and emergent conditions, and medically necessary treatments. Your policy has also been designed to cover prescription medication for new and emergent conditions. You can also purchase insurance for your accompanying family members, as they will need to have insurance also.

Medical Services Plan (MSP)

Medical Service Plan (MSP) is mandatory for all BC residents pursuant to (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents/eligibility-and-enrolment/how-to-enrol) the *Medicare Protection Act*. International students studying on a valid study permit who plan to live in BC for 6 months or more are eligible to enrol in MSP.

Eligibility

- Certain other individuals, such as some holders of Study and/or Work Permits, or Work Permits on Working Holiday Programs — which are issued under the federal *Immigration and Refugee Protection Act* and are valid for a period of six or more months — may be deemed residents. Tourists or visitors to B.C. do not qualify

- If you are on Maintained Status, please see here (https://news.gov.bc.ca/releases/2022HLTH013000679#:~:text=Effective%20May%201%2C%202022%2C%20Medical,on%20their%20applicat for information.

Coverage Wait Period (3 months)

- New (and returning) residents are required to complete a wait period consisting of the balance of the month in which residence in British Columbia is established, plus two months before benefits can begin. New or returning residents arriving from outside Canada should purchase private health insurance for coverage during this period (example Guard.me).

Cost for International Students

- From January 1, 2020, with the elimination of MSP premiums (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/accessing-health-care/health-fee-international-students), the health-care coverage fee for all international students is $75 per month.

PRE-EXISTING CONDITIONS

For those with pre-existing health conditions, including pregnancy, please review the Pre-Existing Conditions section of your GuardMe policy for important information about coverage limitations and available support options. If you have any pre-existing medical conditions/pregnancy, please connect with our Wellness Specialists for a Consultation to find out your options for health care in Canada:

- **Toronto: Ashir Mumtaz (a.mumtaz@northeastern.edu)**
  - Booking Link (https://nam12.safelinks.protection.outlook.com/?url=https%3A%2F%2Foutlook.office.com%2Fbookings%2Fnewmeetingtypecompose%3Fsrc

- **Vancouver: Victoria Williams (v.williams@northeastern.edu)**
  - Booking Link (https://outlook.office365.com/book/WellnessConsult@northeastern.onmicrosoft.com/)

CURRENTLY ENROLLED INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

Toronto Campus

If you are a **returning/continuing student** and you would like to extend your insurance, please see here (https://www.guard.me/neutoronto/department/returning-students/extension-students).

- **You must extend your insurance before the expiry date, but you have a 30 day grace period after the expiry to renew it.** After these 30 days, you will need to purchase an entirely new policy as a New Student which will result in extra costs.

- If you extend your policy **on time**, then you are able to choose the length of time you would like to extend it for, with a minimum time of 122 days.

How do I use GuardMe?

Please check here (https://news.guard.me/GuardMe_Mobile_App.html) for lots of helpful information about using GuardMe.

Graduating Students

If you are graduating, you have **up to 30 days from your health insurance expiry date** to apply for the Recent Graduates health insurance from GuardMe.

The minimum purchase of six (6) months is required, and the maximum you can purchase is one year.

If you miss the 30 day deadline, you will not be eligible for coverage. Before you apply, review the plan available to you, as it may not the same plan that you have had throughout your studies.

You can purchase a Recent Graduate policy here. (https://www.guard.me/neutoronto/department/recent-graduates)

Vancouver Campus

Its important to remember that in most cases your MSP will expire the same time as your immigration document. You must remember to extend your MSP as soon as you receive a new immigration document (such as a Study Permit).

Cost for International Students

- From January 1, 2020, with the elimination of MSP premiums (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/accessing-health-care/health-fee-international-students), the health-care coverage fee for all international students is $75 per month.

MSP Coverage

- Services Covered by MSP (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents/benefits/services-covered-by-msp)
- Services Not Covered by MSP (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents/benefits/services-not-covered-by-msp)
- Typically, your MSP coverage will expire on the same date as your Canadian immigration document, such as the expiry date of your Study Permit or Post-Graduation Work Permit. If you renew your immigration documents, ensure you also update your MSP coverage (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents/managing-your-msp-account/renewing-your-work-permit) once you receive your new study or work permit.

MSP does not cover dental care, prescription drugs, routine vision care such as eye examinations or corrective lenses, and travel. However, you can apply for the PharmaCare Plan (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/pharmacare-for-bc-residents/who-we-cover/fair-pharmacare-plan#eligibility) that is available to those with MSP for additional coverage for prescription drugs, medical devices and pharmacy services.

Be sure to manage your MSP Account and update your information (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-

coverage/msp/bc-residents/managing-your-msp-account) in case of the following changes:

- Change your address
- Change your name
- Permanently leave BC
- Need to add or remove dependents from your coverage (for example, due to marriage, divorce, having a common-law partner, or having children).

For more information and frequently asked questions, please always refer to the BC government website. (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents)

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS (FAQS)

Why do I need Health Insurance?

- As an International Student in Canada, you are **required** to have a valid health insurance that covers all routine and emergency health services. Health care in Canada is extremely expensive if you do not have health insurance. Medical costs incurred in excess of insurance policy limits, or due to expired or non-purchase of insurance, are the sole responsibility of the student. You can find some examples of health care costs in Canada on this guard.me FAQ page (https://www.guard.me/faqs.php) under "Why do I need insurance".
- As a private institution in Canada accepting International Students, we are required to show the provincial governments that our students have valid health insurances to cover their stay in Canada while they study.

Why do I need to purchase Guard.me?

- Health insurance is not included in your tuition fees, it is a separate required cost.

- The Guard.me policy that is provided to our students has been vetted to ensure that it covers essential medical situations. This ensure that our students are getting valid insurance coverage at a discounted price.

- The Guard.me team is able to connect you with many medical resources, doctors, and hospitals in the province where you study and provides you with support throughout any emergencies.

- For Vancouver students, you will need to purchase Guard.me for your first 90 days in Canada because this is the approximate time you will need to wait for your MSP card and it is important to ensure you are covered in case of emergencies.

Can I purchase another health insurance?

- No, Guard.me is the only health insurance that we accept.

- The only exceptions to Guard.me are OHIP, MSP, or UHIP.

- If you purchase another insurance, not from the above list, then you still need to purchase Guard.me.

- Holds will be placed on student accounts for those missing health insurance.

How do I apply for MSP? (Vancouver Students)

- You can apply for MSP using this link (https://www2.gov.bc.ca/gov/content/health/health-drug-coverage/msp/bc-residents/eligibility-and-enrolment/how-to-enrol).

How do I know if I qualify for OHIP? (Toronto Students)

- You can see who is eligible for OHIP here (https://www.ontario.ca/page/apply-ohip-and-get-health-card#section-1).

- Please note that you are responsible for identifying if you are eligible.

What happens after I purchase the Guard.me insurance?

- After you purchase your insurance, you will receive an email with your policy details and your policy card. The

policy card will be a PDF document – Guard.me does not issue physical policy cards.

- Please print your policy card PDF and keep it in a safe place as pharmacies, doctors and hospitals in Canada will require it.

How do I see my Guard.me account and policy details?

- You can see all the details about your policy as well as download your policy card from your Guard.me Account.

- Vancouver Students: You can login to your account here (https://www.guard.me/neuvancouver/myaccount).

- Toronto Students: You can login to your account here (https://www.guard.me/neutoronto/myaccount).

How can I find a doctor or get treatment using Guard.me?

- mobileDOCTOR by Guard.me allows you to connect with Canadian doctors on Maple, a telemedicine company, as a part of your health benefits. Maple provides access to doctors, Canada wide, on your phone, tablet or computer anytime, anywhere.

- Find out more about mobileDOCTOR here:
    - Toronto Students (https://www.guard.me/neutoronto/mobileDOCTOR)
    - Vancouver Students (https://www.guard.me/neuvancouver/mobileDOCTOR)

How can I find a doctor or get treatment using MSP in BC?

- You can use HealthLinkBC (https://www.healthlinkbc.ca/health-services/search-services-your-area) to find a doctor in your area.

- If you would like to find a Family Doctor, you can register on the Health Connect Registry (https://www.healthlinkbc.ca/health-connect-registry).

- For emergency care information, please see here (https://www.vch.ca/en/health-topics/emergency-care).

- You may also connect with the Wellness Program Specialist on the Vancouver Campus for more information about how you can use your MSP card.
    - **Victoria Williams (v.williams@northeastern.edu)**
    - Booking Link (https://outlook.office365.com/book/WellnessConsult@northeastern.onmicrosoft.com/)

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